

DENMARK 2014

Table of Contents

1. Overview of the tax-benefit system.....	2
2. Unemployment insurance	2
3. Unemployment assistance	5
4. Social assistance	6
5. Housing benefits for rented accommodation.....	9
6. Family benefits	11
7. Childcare for pre-school children	12
8. Employment-conditional benefits.....	14
9. Lone-parent benefits VFM	14
10. Tax system.....	16
11. Part-time insurance	18
12. Policy developments.....	19
Social security contributions to general government	21
Social security contributions paid to institutions outside general government	21
Payroll taxes	21

1. Overview of the tax-benefit system

Denmark's unemployment insurance system is voluntary, with around 90 per cent of the workforce covered. The amount of benefit is related to previous earnings subject to a relatively low ceiling. There is no unemployment assistance. Social assistance is administered by local authorities and benefit amounts are determined by national guidelines. Social assistance is contingent on there having been a "social event". Unemployment is such an event, but social assistance is not normally paid to those in work. Housing costs and the number of children are taken into account when calculating social assistance and there is also an income-related housing benefit system. Child benefits are lump-sum amounts depending on the number and age of children and on the number of adults. Subsidised child-care is available to all households. The tax unit is the individual. Social security contributions by employees and, especially, employers are low.

1.1. Average Worker wage (AW)

The national currency is the Kroner (DKK). In 2014, DKK 5.62 was equal to USD 1. In that year, the average worker earned DKK 397 484 (Secretariat estimate)

2. Unemployment insurance

Unemployment insurance is voluntary. The general condition to receive unemployment benefits is membership of an insurance fund for a year. Unemployment insurance includes both employees and self-employed. There are particular rules for self-employed relating to both calculations of benefits and employment conditions. Below we only describe the legislation for employees.

A person can receive unemployment benefits until he reaches his retirement age presently 65 years.

2.1 Conditions for receipt

The unemployed person must be registered with the public employment service as a job seeker and be available for work.

Another element is that the insurance funds must interview each unemployed member every 3rd month in order to control that members receiving unemployment benefits are available for the labour market.

Unemployed members have to register once a week at 'Jobnet' to confirm they are still unemployed and available for the labour market.

If the job loss is 'voluntary' the person will not receive unemployment insurance benefits for the first 3 weeks.

2.1.1 Employment conditions

After 1 924 hours of full-time work within the last three years, the employee is entitled to benefit immediately on becoming unemployed.

2.1.2 *Contribution conditions*

The conditions are satisfied with payment of the membership fee.

2.2 *Calculation of benefit amount*

2.2.1 *Calculation of gross benefit*

The benefit amounts to 90 per cent of previous earnings after deducting 8 per cent social security contributions from those earnings. The maximum yearly benefit is DKK 211 900 (DKK 4 075 per week).

2.2 *Income and earnings disregards for benefit recipients and those starting a new job*

Wages reduce the amount of unemployment benefits (one hour of work reduces the benefit by the value of one hour).

2.3 *Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits*

Unemployment benefits and cash assistance fall under the temporary income relief scheme and are normally taxable. The earnings related contributions are only paid over earned income. Recipients of unemployment benefits do not pay the 8 per cent social security contribution but do pay supplementary pension scheme contributions (fixed amount). Contributions to the unemployment insurance fund (both the unemployment and early retirement insurance contributions) are also made by unemployment insurance beneficiaries.

2.4 *Benefit duration and waiting periods*

The benefit period is 2 years within 3 years. Educational programs do not qualify for extending the period. To re-qualify for benefits, there is a minimum of 1 924 hours of paid employment within the duration of 3 years.

2.4.1 *Temporary benefits to insure a milder implementation of the shortened 2-year period of unemployment benefit*

Insured unemployed persons, who have exhausted their entitlement to unemployment benefit up until the 2nd half year of 2013, are entitled to the special education benefit, payable to persons available for the labour market and accepting a special plan of training/education.

The temporary labour market benefit is given to persons, who have exhausted their entitlement to unemployment benefit and/or the special education benefit during the first half of 2014 and before the end of the first half of 2016. It is a condition that the unemployed person is a member of an unemployment insurance fund, is registered as a job seeker at the public employment centre and is available to the labour market.

Both the special education benefit and the temporary labour market benefit consist of 60% of the maximum rate of unemployment benefit for non-providers and 80% for providers. Both benefits are independent of spouse's income and total family wealth.

The duration of the special education benefit is 6 months and gradually phased out by the end of 2014. The duration of the labour market benefit is up to 1¼ years in 2014 and is gradually shortened as well as phased out by the end of 2017. The total period of unemployment benefit, the special education benefit and temporary labour market benefit can last for a maximum of 4 years.

2.5 *Supplementary benefits*

A member who is working reduced hours may receive supplementary benefits for a limited period if the employer waives any notice of termination. Supplementary benefits are paid on the basis of the member's individual rate of unemployment benefits. A person who is working part-time on a permanent basis may receive supplementary benefits for 30 weeks within a period of 104 weeks. It is also possible to receive supplementary benefits in connection with temporary lay-offs due to bad weather or lack of materials, unless the employer has a duty to pay special benefit compensation.

No benefits are paid in respect of an unemployment period of less than 7,4 hours per week.

2.6 *Treatment of particular groups*

2.6.1 *Young persons*

For graduates who have joined the unemployment insurance funds immediately after graduating the unemployment benefit amounts to 82 per cent of the maximum unemployment benefit i.e. DKK 3 340 per week (DKK 173 680 per year).

The unemployment benefit for younger persons (under 25) without sufficient education for the "graduate" rights amounts to 50% of the maximum unemployment benefit, per week DKK 2 040 (DKK 106 080 per year)

2.6.2 *Older workers*

Members of an unemployment insurance fund who have reached the age of early retirement (currently 60 years) and as a main rule have been members of an unemployment insurance fund for 30 years and who have paid contributions for voluntary early retirement in a corresponding period are entitled to voluntary early retirement pay until they reach the retirement age (currently 65 years). The early retirement pay is paid at an individually calculated rate, see section 2.2.1 but for a maximum of 91 per cent of the maximum unemployment benefits which corresponds to DKK 3 710 per week (DKK 192 920 per year) if they go into voluntary early retirement as soon as they reach the age of early retirement (currently the age of 60). If the transition into voluntary early retirement is put off for a minimum of 2 years and if the member in this period has worked for a minimum of 3,120 hours the voluntary early retirement pay is paid at the rate of 100 per cent of the maximum unemployment benefits, see section 2.2.1 corresponding to DKK 4 075 per week (DKK 211 900 per year). Members do not have a duty to be available for work but they may work for an unlimited number of hours with an hour-to-hour deduction.

2.6.3 *Temporary benefit for unemployed persons with a permanently reduced capacity to work, who have been admitted to the so called "flexible -job" scheme.*

A flexible job is exclusively offered to persons with a permanently reduced capacity to work, who have exhausted all possible offers of rehabilitative training without gaining reentry to the ordinary labour market. In the event of unemployment a temporary benefit ("ledighedsydelse") is paid by the municipality until another flexible job is offered. The flexible job scheme and the "ledighedsydelse" are administered by the municipalities. It is not a requirement for the person to be a member of an

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unemployment insurance fund. A special early retirement scheme also exists for persons admitted to the flexible job scheme.

3. Unemployment assistance

There is no unemployment assistance in Denmark (see social assistance below).

4. Social assistance

Payment rates are depending on the ages, so that people between the ages of 18 and 29 receive less than people who are 30 years or more.

4.1 Conditions for receipt

A “social event”, such as unemployment, must have taken place; a low income is not in itself a social event. If social assistance is being received due to unemployment, job search will be enforced.

The Danish social assistance system is for both people who are ready for the labour market and people who have other problems than unemployment. For people who are ready for the labour market job-search is a condition for becoming (and remaining) entitled to social assistance. The other group has to satisfy other conditions such as sickness treatment and/or activation to be entitled.

For persons under the age of 30 without education or training leading to a vocational/professional qualification it is a condition that they embark on a course that will give them the qualification needed to find a job. If they are not ready to start education or training, they must instead begin an activity that will prepare them for education or training. Social assistance for this group of people is called educational assistance.

Social assistance is the lowest security net in the Danish system, but low income as such is not a condition for becoming entitled to social cash benefits. It is possible to “top-up” low unemployment benefits, but normally people who are entitled to unemployment benefit do not satisfy the conditions for receiving social assistance (i.e. social assistance is depending on savings and spouse income and savings) and normally the unemployment benefit is higher than cash benefit.

4.2 Calculation of benefit amount

4.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

For persons over 30 years the assistance amounts to DKK 14.203 which approximately corresponds to 80% of the maximum unemployment insurance benefit for those with dependent children and DKK 10.689 for others, which approximately corresponds to 60% of the maximum unemployment insurance benefit.

For persons under the age of 30 without education or training leading to a vocational/professional qualification the educational assistance amounts to DKK 5 857, corresponding to the Danish student’s Grants (SU). For persons without dependent children the benefit amounts to DKK 8 196 for persons (non-single parents) with dependent children and DKK 11 712 for single parents with dependent children.

For persons under the age of 30 with an education or training leading to a vocational/professional qualification the social assistance amounts are less than social assistance for persons over 30 years but higher than educational assistance, see section 4.5.1.

Social assistance is calculated for the individual. For married couples the benefits are based on the income and savings of both spouses. A married couple may receive the sum of their individual social assistance amounts combined subtracted any income the couple earn. The same rules apply for cohabiting (unmarried) couples over the age of 25, where one or both of them are receiving social assistance or education benefit.

4.2.1.1 *Irregular additional payments*

The municipal authority may provide assistance towards reasonable individual expenses incurred by a person due to a change of circumstances if the payment of such expenses by the person concerned would seriously reduce the possibilities of that person and his/her family of providing for themselves in the future. Normally assistance shall only be granted if the expense has arisen as a result of unforeseeable needs. The municipal authority may exceptionally, having considered the individual circumstances of each case, cover foreseeable expenses where the payment of such expenses is of vital importance to the possibilities of the person concerned or his/her family.

The municipal authority may provide temporary rent payment to a person, who is threatened by eviction due to missing rent payments. It is a condition that the person is financially incapable of paying for the cost him-/herself.

The municipal authority may provide assistance towards any necessary and reasonable health care expenses, medicine, dental treatment, etc., which are not covered under any other legislation if the applicant is financially incapable of paying such expenses.

The municipal authority provides grants for dental care to persons who are receiving benefits after the Active Social Policy Act equivalent to the level of social assistance on condition that the person is financially incapable of paying for the cost him-/herself.

The municipal authority may provide assistance towards expenses incurred in connection with the applicant's exercise of access rights to his/her own children under the age of 18 years who are not living with the applicant. It is a condition of assistance being provided in this case, that the applicant is financially incapable of paying the said expenses.

The municipal authority may provide assistance towards travel costs for the purpose of maintaining contact with children who have been removed to another country without the consent of the custodial parent. It is a condition that the matter has been reported to the Danish police, and that the municipal authority has presented the case to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. It is also a condition that the custodial parent is financially incapable of paying the said costs.

The municipal authority may provide assistance towards the expenses of maintaining a child where – upon the death of the custodial parent – custody has been awarded to one or more persons who are not subject to a duty to maintain the child. It is a condition that the child's income, including special child benefits under the Act on Child Benefits Act and advance payment of child maintenance, is not sufficient to cover the necessary expenses for maintaining the child.

The municipal authority may provide assistance for a relocation with the purpose of improving the housing or employment situation of the applicant or his/her family. It is a condition that neither the applicant nor his/her spouse is financially capable of paying the expenses. If the applicant is moving to another country, it is a condition of assistance being provided by the municipal authority that the applicant is a national of or has a particular connection to the country in question, or that the applicant has been secured permanent employment opportunities in the said country.

Upon application Udbetaling Danmark shall pay a survivor's allowance to any person whose husband/wife or cohabiting partner has died. Payment of the allowance shall be subject to the surviving dependant having cohabited with the deceased at a joint address in Denmark for the last three years immediately preceding the death. The maximum amount of the allowance is DKK 13 904, and it shall be payable to any dependent survivor whose estimated annual income does not exceed DKK 228 905. If the estimated annual

income exceeds the amount set out in the first sentence hereof, the allowance will be reduced, and if the estimated annual income exceeds DKK 357 662, no survivor's allowance shall be payable.

4.2.1.2 *Obligations of family members*

The obligation on the applicant to be available for the labour market/activation also applies the applicant's spouse or cohabiting partner.

If a spouse or cohabiting partner refuses to satisfy the conditions for getting social assistance, none of the spouses or partners can get social assistance.

4.2.2 *Income and earnings disregards for benefit recipients and those starting a new job*

If the applicant or his or her spouse has income from work a sum of DKK 25 per hour worked (up to a maximum of 160 hour per month) shall not be deducted from the total benefits payable.

4.3 *Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits*

Recipients of social assistance pay income tax. They do not pay the 8 per cent social security contribution but do pay the supplementary pension scheme contributions if they have received social assistance for an uninterrupted period of twelve months.

4.4 *Benefit duration and waiting periods*

No limit.

4.5 *Treatment of particular group*

4.5.1 *Young people*

Unemployed persons under 30 who have an education receive social assistance DKK 6 889 if they do not reside with one or both parent. The social assistance is reduced to DKK 3 324 if they are residing with one or both parents.

Persons under the age of 30 who don't have an education receive educational assistance rather than ordinary social assistance. If they do not reside with one or both parents the benefit is DKK 5 857. The benefit is DKK 2 524 if they are residing with one or both parents.

4.5.2 *Calculation of gross benefits - special housing benefit for people receiving social assistance*

For families without children, net housing costs (gross housing costs minus general housing benefits) exceeding DKK 2 800 per month is paid. For families with children, all net rent above DKK 4 000 per month per adult is paid, reduced by DKK 750 for each child other than the first.

The total amount of social assistance after tax and special housing benefit is subject to one of two maxima, depending either on previous income or the maximum unemployment benefit. In the first case, the sum of special housing benefit and the person's other income after tax, including the total amount of social assistance, may not exceed 90% of previous net earnings when in work.

In the second case, when social assistance has been paid to a person for an uninterrupted period of three months, the sum of special housing benefits and the person's other income after tax must not exceed the amount of maximum unemployment benefit payable under the act on unemployment insurance after tax. The maximum amount of unemployment benefit before tax that a person can receive each month is DKK 17 658 ($\approx 4.33 * \text{DKK } 4\,075$).

4.5.4 *Older workers*

There are no rules for older workers in this scheme.

4.5.5 *Others if applicable*

No special schemes.

5. **Housing benefits for rented accommodation**

5.1 *Conditions for receipt*

Housing benefits in Denmark are granted on an individual household basis. There are in principle two different sets of rules. Originally "boligsikring" was introduced in the late 1960's and included a 60% initial benefit of paid rent for all types of income receivers. Later in 1979 a considerable more favourable "boligyldelse" was introduced with a 75% benefit calculated on the rent.

Both benefits involves rather complicated calculations that includes a normalized rent, house size, level of household income etc., and the two schemes have their own parameters of calculation.

Today the first scheme "boligsikring" is primarily aimed at households without persons receiving age pensions. The second scheme "boligyldelse" is only for recipients of old age pension and disability benefits (pension rules before 2003). This scheme is considerably more expensive than "boligsikring" and dominantly paid to elderly people who receive a larger part of public age pension and live as singles.

5.2 *Calculation of benefits*

5.2.1 *Calculation of gross benefits — general housing benefits*

General terms:

The actual paid rent excl. consumption of electricity, antenna, gas and warm water is the basis for housing benefits. The rent is corrected for the indicative size of the apartment expressed in square meters. The correction factor is the sum of 45 m² plus 20 m² per household member divided by the actual m². Corrected rent will - if it exceeds certain limits depending on family size - be reduced to a maximum allowed (subsidized) level.

Thresholds and parameters in calculation of housing benefits (in DKK), 2014

Scheme	% benefits of rent	Threshold	% above	Threshold raised per child (2-4)	Maximum benefit	Minimum own payment
Boligsikring	60	140 500	18	37 000	41 592	23 700

Boligydelse	75	149 300	22½	39 300	44 184	15 800 ¹⁾
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¹⁾ But never less than 11% of total household income.

Walkthrough the calculations of “boligsikring”

In this scheme, maximum subsidized rent is DKK 78800 for households without children and if there are children the maximum is increased by 5% per child, max 20 per cent.

General housing benefits – rent subsidy (boligsikring) (in DKK), 2014

Number of children	0	1	2	3	4 or more
Max. subsidized rent per year	78 800	82 700	86 700	90 600	94 600
Max. benefit per year ¹⁾	41 592	41 592	41 592	41 592	51 996

1) Benefits can’t exceed 15% of the rent in families without pensioners or children.

For households in the “boligsikring” scheme the subsidy is calculated as 60% of the rent. There is an income dependable deduction by 18% of the household income beyond DKK 140 500. However as a special case for household with no kids or pensioners the housing benefits cannot exceed 15% of the rent.

For households with children the rent subsidy is also calculated as 60% of the rent and then deducted by 18% of the household income beyond DKK 140 500. If there is more than one child in the household, this threshold is raised by DKK 37 000 per child up to max DKK 251 500.

Households in this scheme can receive housing benefits up till DKK 41 592. If there are more than three children in the household, this amount is raised by 25% to DKK 51 996.

Regardless of the benefit calculated in this way households must always pay at least DKK 23 700 out of the payable rent.

A minimum triviality limit is applied under which no benefit is paid. This amount is DKK 3 048.

Walkthrough the calculations of “boligydelse”

For all households benefits is calculated as 75% of the rent. The rent is always added DDK 6 300 before calculating the initial benefits. The income deduction is done by 22.5% of the household incomes beyond DKK 149 300. If there are 2 or more children in the household this threshold is raised by DKK 39 300 per child up to max DDK 267 200.

Households can receive benefits up till DKK 44 184. If there are more than three children in the household, this amount is always 25% higher. If pensioners are referred to specific housing due to specific needs, there is no limit to this amount.

Regardless of the benefit calculated in this way households must always pay at least DKK 15 800 out of the payable rent and at least 11% of the household income.

5.3 Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits

All housing benefits are non-taxable.

5.4 Treatment of particular groups

There are no housing benefits exclusively for young people, older workers or others. These groups are entitled to rent subsidy on the same terms as other applicants, with no regards to age. Income, capital, rent, size of the apartment and number of children (if any) are the only factors which are taken into account when measuring out the rent subsidy.

Physically handicapped persons fall under the same rules. However, there are favourable adjustments in some rates and percentage rules, meaning that larger housing and higher rent is subsidised.

6. Family benefits

6.1 Conditions for receipt

Children below the age of 18 qualify the family for child and youth allowance. Prior to 2011 this benefit scheme was called family allowance. The allowance provided is age dependent. As of January 1st 2011, for children aged 0 to 14 the allowance is given in accordance with the child allowance scheme, which contains three subgroups (children aged 0-2, 3-6, and 7-14). For children aged 15 to 17 the allowance is given in accordance with the youth allowance scheme.

Under certain conditions the entitlement to child- and youth allowance can lapse. This is the case, for instance, if the child does not follow a specified education plan and therefore is neither studying nor working.

As a main rule the recipient of the allowance is the mother.

6.2 Calculation of benefit amount

6.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

Age group	Quarterly amount (DKK) for each child
0 – 2	4 404
3 – 6	3 486
7 – 17	2 745

For children aged 0 to 14 the allowance is paid out in quarterly amounts, while for children aged 15-17 the amount is paid out in monthly rates.

In 2011 there is a ceiling at DKK 35 000 on the possible amount of child and youth allowance received in the course of a year. However, at most 1/3 of the total child- and youth allowance received in excess of DKK 35 000 can be cut or at most DKK 12 000. Only families with more than two children will be affected by this ceiling¹.

6.2.1.1 Irregular additional payments

6.2.2 Income and earnings disregards

Child and youth allowance is not subject to any means test.

¹ The ceiling was introduced as of January 1st 2011 as part of the Fiscal Consolidation Agreement in 2010, but will be lifted as of January 1st 2012.

6.3 Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits

Family benefits are not taxable.

6.4 Treatment of particular groups

6.4.1 Young persons

6.4.2 Older workers

6.4.3 Others if applicable

Lone parents receive normal family benefits, but also qualify for extra child benefit of DKK 5 380 per year (independent of the number of children) plus DKK 5 276 as ordinary child benefit per child aged 0-17.

Parents with multiple births receive DKK 0 for the first child and DKK 8 700 for the following child from 0-6 years of age.

Orphan's supplement: Full orphans receive DKK 30 480 a year; half-orphans receive DKK 15 240. The supplement is payable to children who have lost one or both parents, when paternity cannot be determined, when the mother is a single woman following artificial insemination and when the child has been adopted by a single person.

Children of pensioners supplement: Children of pensioners receive DKK 13 488 a year per child (one pensioner parent) or DKK 15 240 a year per child, plus DKK 5 276 per year per child if both parents are pensioners. The supplement is paid quarterly and is means tested against the income of the parents (only the large supplements of 13 488 and 15 240). The total amount of received special child allowance is reduced by 3% of the total income (wage income + capital income) that exceeds the income level where pensions supplement lapses. In the event where a family receives several special child allowances the reduction is shared equally among these.

Adoption grant: For the adoption of a foreign child, a single lump sum of DKK 50 119.

Students' child benefit: A total of up to DKK 6 928 is under certain conditions payable a year for each parent who is studying. The supplement is paid quarterly and is depending of the income of the parents.

Supplementary child benefit in trainee or school practice: Family breadwinners can in certain periods of training or education receive a supplementary child benefit of 55 percent of the difference between his or her trainee or school practice allowance (incl. any other income) and the state education grant with a breadwinner allowance. The supplementary child benefit will lift their total income to a level equivalent to the comparable state education grant with a breadwinner allowance.

7. **Childcare for pre-school children**

The fraction of children in childcare (by age and type of childcare) is shown in the table below (2011).

Age	Family day care	Day-care institutions	Afterschool centers	All
0	9,86%	8,9%	0,0%	18,7%
1-2	36,1%	54,8%	0,1%	91,0%
3-5	0,2%	90,6%	6,6%	97,4%

Note: Children aged 3-5 can attend afterschool centers, without having started compulsory schooling.

Compulsory schooling starts the year the child turns 6 years.

7.1 ***Out-of-pocket childcare fees paid by parents***

The average fee paid per year by parents for full time day-care in 2013 is shown in the table below. Parents with low incomes pay less (see section 7.2) and there is also a price-reduction if the parent(s) have more than one child in day-care. In the average fee paid for a child in day-care institutions the price include lunch, even if the parent(s) pay this rate separate. In family day-care lunch is always included in the fee.

Age	Day-care institution	Family day-care
0-2	32.980	28.284
3-5	19.095	25.704

*Childcare fees are not tax deductible

Fees are not taken into account when determining entitlement to benefits such as social assistance, but the fee you pay depend on your income, see section 7.2.

7.2 ***Child-care benefits***

7.2.1 *Conditions for receipt*

Subsidised day-care is available to all households with young children in day-care.

7.2.2 *Calculation of benefit amount*

7.2.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

Parents pay a maximum of 25% of the budgeted gross operating expenditure for day-care services for children from 26 weeks to age six. The parents of a child are from July 1st. 2006 guaranteed day-care when the child is 26 weeks until school age.

There is no charge for day-care if the personal income [gross income net of general social security contributions] is below DKK 158 801. From DKK 158 801 to DKK 162 321 the payment is 5% of the full rate. From that income level, the payment is linearly increased until the full price is paid at a personal income of DKK 493 299, i.e. the payment is increased by 1 percentage point for every income increment of DKK 3 521. There are special discount rates for single-parents: the scale for calculating the payment in per cent of the full rate for financially aided place subsidy increases with DKK 55 559 for each level of income.

There are special discount rates for siblings: if a family has more than one child in day care, the full price is charged for the child in the most expensive day care facility and half the price is charged for all the remaining children in day care. The discount for siblings is calculated subsequently.

7.2.2.2 Income and earnings disregards

See above

7.2.3 Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits

The benefit is not taxable.

7.2.4 Treatment of particular groups

Parents of children with special social problems can have a supplemental subsidy in addition to the above-mentioned subsidy (see section 7.2.1).

8. Employment-conditional benefits

There are no benefits targeted on people in work.

9. Lone-parent benefits

Lone parents receive normal family benefits (section 6.2.1) but also qualify for additional payments of DKK 5 380 per year (independent of the number of children) plus DKK 5 276 per child aged 0-17 (section 6.4.3).

In addition, for each child, a lone parent widow or widower can receive a special child allowance, (orphan's supplement) amounting to DKK 15 240 a year. Should the child be an orphan the supplement doubles. .

There is a state transfer of DKK 15 240 per year for each dependent child in case an 'absent parent' does not contribute (this amount) to the family (alimony). The state advances the money and then demands the absent parent to pay it in full or in part. This transfer is included in the calculations for single parents.

The alimony payment consists of a basic amount which is DKK 13 488 / year and a supplement which is DKK 1 752 /year (2014 numbers). Altogether, for each child the alimony payment is DKK 15 240 /year.

Every year a set of guidelines are published, which suggest the size of income that leads to a raise in the alimony payment. It is important to emphasise that it is only a recommendation, not a fixed rule.

According to the guidelines, the alimony payment is raised with 100% of the basic amount, when an absent parent with one child earns more than DKK 480 000 /year. This income limitation is raised according to the number of children of the absent parent.

The percentage of the basic amount, which is added, is raised according to the income of the absent parent, up to 300 %.

The table below shows the actual suggested approximately income limits (2014). .

Alimony payment +	1 child	2 children	3 children	4 children	5 children
	Approximately income limits (DDK)				
100 %	480.000	530.000	600.000	700.000	820.000
200 %	700.000	800.000	900.000	1.100.000	1.200.000
300 %	1.200.000	1.500.000	1.700.000	1.900.000	2.100.000

9.1 Conditions for receipt

All parents who in reality are lone-parents are in titled to the benefit.

9.2 Calculation of benefit amount

The benefit is not affected by parent income.

9.3 Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits

The benefit is not taxable.

9.4 Benefit duration

As long as the parent in reality is alone, they are entitled to the benefit.

10. Tax system

10.1 Income tax

10.1.1 Tax allowances and credits

10.1.1.1 Standard allowances

If a wage or salary earner has expenses related to earning his income (e.g. transport, trade union membership dues, unemployment premiums) these expenses are fully deductible against taxable income.

The tax credit scheme allows the taxpayer to deduct 7.65 per cent of earned income to a maximum of DKK 25 000 in order to calculate taxable income. Single parents get an extra employment allowance of 5.40 per cent in 2014 with a maximum allowance of DKK 17 700. The effective value of the credit is equal to the municipality tax (24.9 per cent), the church tax rate (0.7 per cent) plus the 5.0 per cent health care tax rate that is paid to the state (30.62 per cent on average) multiplied by the value of the deduction.

In this report contributions to unemployment insurance are considered as a standard tax allowance (*and as a social security contribution*).

10.1.1.2 Standard tax credits

Each person is granted a personal allowance, which is converted into a tax credit by applying the marginal tax rate of the first bracket of the income tax schedule. For a person 18 years of age and older the tax credit amounts to:

For central government income tax	6.83 per cent of DKK 42 800 = DKK 2 923
For central government health tax	5.0 per cent of DKK 42 800 = DKK 2 140
For local government income tax and church tax (average rate)	25.62 per cent of DKK 42 800 = DKK 10 965

Special personal allowance for an individual younger than 18 years: DKK 32 100.

If a married person cannot utilise the personal allowance, the unutilised part is transferred to the spouse.

Individuals older than 18 years receive a 'green check' of DKK 1 300; this amount is increased with DKK 300 per child for up to two children. Only one partner in a married couple receives the increased 'green check' for children. The 'green check' is nominally fixed and is quickly phased out at a rate of 7.5 per cent for income above DKK 369 400. If the yearly income of the individuals is lower than DKK 215 900 the individuals receive an 'additional green check' of DKK 280.

10.1.2 Income tax schedule

Low bracket tax to the central government is assessed on the aggregate of personal income and positive net capital income at the rate of 6.83 pct.

From 2010 and onwards the medium tax bracket was removed.

Top bracket tax to the central government is assessed on the excess of DKK 449 100 of the aggregate of personal income and positive net capital income at the rate of 15 per cent. If a married individual cannot utilise the total allowance of DKK 449 100, the unutilised part is not transferred to the spouse.

If the marginal tax rate including local tax but excluding church tax exceeds 51.7 per cent, the top bracket tax rate is reduced by the difference between the marginal tax rate and 51.7 per cent.

10.1.3 State and local income taxes

Local income taxes are levied by the municipalities (and the church). They are flat-rate taxes levied by the local authorities (the rate varies by jurisdiction).

The tax base is taxable income. Tax credit varies with tax rates. The average amount is given below including the state health contribution of 5%.

- Lowest rate: 22.5 per cent
- Highest rate: 27.8 per cent
- Average rate: 25.617 per cent (municipalities: 24.902 per cent; church: 0.715 per cent).

The average rate is used in this study. It is applied to the tax base less personal allowances.

10.2 Treatment of family income

The tax unit is the individual. Spouses are taxed separately, but the tax liability of a married individual may depend on the spouse's income.

10.3 Social security contributions

10.3.1 Employees' contributions

Employees make a fixed contribution of DKK 10 837 for unemployment insurance. From 1999 onwards, the contribution for unemployment insurance is split into two: one part consists of the contribution for unemployment insurance (DKK 3 912) while the other part consists of a voluntary contribution to an early retirement scheme (DKK 5 700). In addition an administration fee of DKK 1 401 on average is added.

Contributions to the unemployment funds are not mandatory. Nevertheless these payments are defined as social security contributions and classified as taxes in the Danish national accounts because there is no direct link between what members pay to the schemes and what they receive and the funds are subsidized by the state. In this report, both contributions as well as the administration fee are included.

In addition, there is a compulsory fixed contribution to a *general* Supplementary Pension Scheme of DKK 1080 for workers who work at least 117 hours per month; their employer makes a corresponding contribution that is double this amount (for workers who work less than 117 hours but not less than 78 hours, the rate is DKK 720; for workers who work less than 78 hours but not less than 39 hours, the rate is DKK 360). Under this scheme, each employee has a plan and it should be noted that the contribution that is ascribed to this plan is determined by the level of employment and does not necessarily relate to the actual amount described above. For the purposes of this Report, only the fixed contribution of DKK 1 080 is included in the tax calculations.

10.3.2 Employers' contributions

From 2000 and on the employer social security contribution is zero. The employer only contributes to a *general* Labour Market Supplementary Pension scheme, which for a full-time employee corresponds to a fixed amount of DKK 2 160 (Twice the fixed amount of DKK 1 080 mentioned above).

11. Part-time insurance

11.1 *Special benefit rules for part-time insurance*

The general condition is membership of an insurance fund for the last year. After 34 weeks of full-time work within the last three years, the employee is entitled to benefits immediately on becoming unemployed. The maximum unemployment benefit is reduced to two-thirds.

11.2 *Special tax and social security contribution rules for part-time insurance*

The 8 per cent general social security contribution is proportional to earned income. If the employee is insured part-time, s/he pays two thirds of the unemployment and early retirement insurance contributions. The DKK 1 080 fixed amount supplementary pension contributions are paid in proportion to the number of hours worked per week. Regarding the part-time employees the fixed amount paid is DKK 720 for employees working from 78 and up to 117 hours per month, DKK 360 for employees working from 39 and up to 78 hours per month and DKK 0 for employees working less than 39 hours per month. Also for these groups the employer pays twice.

The 8 per cent general social security contribution is proportional to earned income – and is only paid on earned income.

If the employee is insured part-time, s/he pays two thirds of the unemployment and early retirement insurance contributions. The individual employee decides how much s/he wants to be insured – full-time or part-time. The same contribution is paid for everyone - for employed, unemployed, part-time employed and for those who receive benefits and work part-time.

The fixed amount paid to the *general* Supplementary Pension Scheme varies with the number of hours worked. If the employee only works part-time and for the remaining hours receives benefits, or does not work and receives benefits, s/he also pays a fixed amount of the benefits to the *general* Supplementary Pension Scheme. Typically this amount is DKK 1.28 for every hour s/he receives the benefit based on a working week of 37 hours. In the model calculations we assume that the same amount applies to recipients of Social Assistance and Unemployment Benefits.

12. Policy developments

12.1 Policy changes introduced: 2nd July 2013 – 1st July 2014

The Cash Benefit Reform (2013)

The political agreement behind the reform was reached in April 2013. Legislation to enact the reform was passed July – December 2013 (Act No. 894 of 4th July 2013 and Act No. 1612 of 26th December 2013) and entered into force on 1 January 2014. The reform meant a number of changes to the activation measures and benefit structure of the social assistance system.

One of the main objectives of the reform was to give young unemployed persons a targeted effort through education and training leading to professional and vocational qualifications that will enable them to find a job. At the same time, person over 30 years and persons with education, who suffer from long term unemployment, should obtain employment through different initiatives qualifying them for employment.

As a consequence, the activation measures in the Danish social assistance system now seek to address specific groups through specific measures. They can for instance be offered a pre-course at an educational institution (building bridge to an education), wage subsidies or job training in a private business.

As part of the activation measures, young people under the age of 30 without education or training leading to vocational/professional qualifications are supposed to embark on a course that will give them the qualification needed to find a job – they are regarded as ready for education.

As a consequence, youths cannot receive (ordinary) social assistance but will instead receive educational assistance (read more below).

If not ready for education, i.e. the person *cannot* embark on a course of education on ordinary terms within a particular period - they are regarded as *ready for activity*. They then have to take part in activities that make them ready for education. This is also the case for persons over 30 or persons with an education, who are not regarded as ready to find a job.

Raising the age limit of being eligible to receive social assistance to 30 years

As a consequence of the cash benefit reform the age for being eligible to receive social assistance has been raised to 30 years. Young persons under 30 years without education or training leading to vocational/professional qualifications will instead receive educational assistance, which is social assistance on a lower level, corresponding to the assistance offered under the Danish state education grant, until they complete their education.

Mutual support between cohabiting partners in the social assistance system

Another element in the Cash Benefit Reform was the introduction of the obligation of cohabiting partners 25 years of age or older who apply for or receive social assistance to provide for one another.

2014 is a transitional year where the rules will have half effect. To calculate the monthly entitlement of a cohabiting partner in the transitional year of 2014 the following to sums are added, then divided by two: (A) the monthly entitlement for the person calculated on basis of full mutual support and (B) the monthly entitlement for the person calculated on the basis of no mutual support.

Change in the deductions per hour for income from work

Act No. 166 of 26th February raises the tax deductions for income earned from working from DKK 15, 23 per hour to DKK 25, 00 per hour, for people receiving social assistance or education benefit. This means that the recipients, who are working part time, will have a greater gain from working and thus increase their incentive to work.

Temporary rent payment for people threatened by eviction

Act No. 723 of 25th June 2014 authorises the municipal authority to provide temporary rent payment to a person, who is threatened by eviction due to missing rent payments. It is a condition that the person is financially incapable of paying for the cost him-/herself and only for a limited period of time. The target group is especially families with children or socially vulnerable families.

12.2 Future policy changes announced since 1st July 2014

Temporary labour market cash benefit

In Act No. 174 of 24th February 2015 on temporary labour market cash benefit, a new type of benefit will be introduced – temporary labour market cash benefit – payable in respect of persons who from 2015 will exhaust their right to unemployment benefits, and the temporary labour market benefit and who are not eligible for (full) social assistance.

The total period of unemployment benefit, temporary labour market benefit and temporary labour market cash benefit may not exceed 3 years (in 2013). Thus, temporary labour market cash benefits may be paid in a period between ¼ to ½ years, depending on the time, the end of the 2-year period of unemployment benefits.

Temporary labour market cash benefit amounts to a monthly sum of DKK 10.849 for persons over 30 years of age without children (2015) and DKK 14.416 for parents over 30 years of age (2015). The monthly amount for persons under 30 years of age is calculated according to the principles for calculation of social assistance.

Temporary labour market cash benefit is independent of spouse's income and total family wealth.

In order to be entitled to the temporary labour market cash benefit the unemployed person must be available for the labour market. This means, that the person is actively job seeking and can obtain work with a day's notice.

Mutual obligation for cohabiting couples to provide for another to expire by January 1st 2016

Act nr. 1522 of 27th December 2014 on changing the law on Active Social Policy repeals the rules of mutual obligations for cohabiting partners to provide for one another. The rules will be repealed on 1 January 2016. 2015 is a transitional year where the rules will have half effect. To calculate the monthly entitlement of a cohabiting partner in the transitional year of 2015 the following two sums are added, then divide by two: (A) the monthly entitlement for the person calculated on basis of full mutual support and (B) the monthly entitlement for the person calculated on the basis of no mutual support.

ANNEX

DEFINITION OF SOCIAL SECURITY CONTRIBUTIONS AND PAYROLL TAXES.

The following text has been adapted from Annex A of the OECD *Revenue Statistics*.

Social security contributions to general government

Classified here are all compulsory payments that confer an entitlement to receive a (contingent) future social benefit. Such payments are usually earmarked to finance social benefits and are often paid to institutions of general government that provide such benefits. However, such earmarking is not part of the definition of social security contributions and is not required for a tax to be classified here. However, conferment of an entitlement is required for a tax to be classified under this heading. So, levies on income or payroll that are earmarked for social security funds but do not confer an entitlement to benefit are excluded from this heading and shown under personal income taxes or taxes on payroll and workforce. Taxes on other bases, such as goods and services, which are earmarked for social security benefits are not shown here [...] because they generally confer no entitlement to social security benefits.

Contributions for the following types of social security benefits would, *inter alia*, be included: unemployment insurance benefits and supplements, accident, injury and sickness benefits, old-age, disability and survivors' pensions, family allowances, reimbursements for medical and hospital expenses or provision of hospital or medical services. Contributions may be levied on both employees and employers.

Social security contributions paid to institutions outside general government

Contributions to social insurance schemes which are not institutions of general government and to other types of insurance schemes, provident funds, pension funds, friendly societies or other saving schemes [are included here if they are compulsory or quasicompulsory (e.g., by virtue of agreement with professional and union organisations)]. Provident funds are arrangements under which the contributions of each employee and of the corresponding employer on his/her behalf are kept in a separate account earning interest and withdrawable under specific circumstances. Pension funds are separately organised schemes negotiated between employees and employers and carry provisions for different contributions and benefits, sometimes more directly tied to salary levels and length of service than under social security schemes.

Payroll taxes

This heading covers taxes paid by employers or employees either as a proportion of payroll or as a fixed amount per person, and which do not confer entitlement to social benefits. Examples of taxes classified here are the United Kingdom national insurance surcharge (introduced in 1977), the Swedish payroll tax (1969-1979), and the Austrian Contribution to the Family Burden Equalisation Fund and Community Tax.